

English Vocabulary - English Vocabulary

PUBLICATION METADATA

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BOOK HIGHLIGHTS & LEARNING FEATURES

- ' Structured 14-Section Comprehensive Mastery Layout
- ' Visual Memory Cards, Mnemonics & Sound Associations
- ' Exam Trend Analysis, PYQ Notes & Shortcut Formulas
- ' High-Retention Active Recall & Common Mistake Alerts
- ' Quick Revision Summary & One-Page Exam Formula Sheet

One-Word Substitutions

Learning Objectives

By the end of this chapter, you will master:

- The Etymological Approach: Deciphering the meanings of unfamiliar words using classical Latin and Greek roots, prefixes, and suffixes.
- High-Yield Root Groups: Recognizing and applying over 50 essential root words that frequently appear in competitive exams (SSC CGL, CHSL, Banking, State PSC, UPSC).
- Contextual Semantic Analysis: Identifying synonyms and antonyms by analyzing sentence tone and structural clues.
- Precision in One-Word Substitutions: Mastering thematic categories such as government types (-cracy / -archy), phobias (-phobia), manias (-mania), and killings (-cide*).
- Exam-Style Elimination Tactics: Applying systematic elimination methods to solve vocabulary questions with 100% accuracy under intense time pressure.

Quick Overview & Chapter Roadmap

Vocabulary is the cornerstone of the English Language section in all major competitive exams. Instead of rote memorization—which is inefficient and prone to cognitive fatigue—this chapter presents a structured, scientific approach to vocabulary acquisition.

By understanding how words are built, you can instantly break down a 12-letter word into manageable units to deduce its meaning.

[THE VOCABULARY TREE]

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[Etymology & Roots]

Prefix + Root + Suffix

(e.g., In- + Cred + -ible)

- Phobias & Manias

[Thematic Groups]

- Crimes & Killings (-cide)

- Forms of Gov. (-cracy)

EXAM TREND & FOCUS

EXAM FOCUS:

KEY NOTE

SSC Exams (CGL, CHSL, CPO): Vocabulary accounts for nearly 40-50% of the English section through Synonyms, Antonyms, One-Word Substitutions, Idioms, and Misspelled Words.

KEY NOTE

Banking Exams (IBPS, SBI PO/Clerk): Vocab is tested contextually through Reading Comprehension, Cloze Tests, and Double Fillers.

KEY NOTE

State PSC & UPSC (CDS, NDA): Direct synonym-antonym matches and sentence completion items are highly frequent.

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Main Concepts & Formulas

The Anatomy of a Word

Most English words are constructed from three fundamental components:

Prefix + Root Word + Suffix = New Word

- Prefix: Attached to the beginning* of a word to alter its direction or tone (often making it negative, positive, or spatial).
- Root Word: The core semantic unit carrying the primary meaning. It cannot be further broken down.
- Suffix: Attached to the end* of a word to determine its part of speech (Noun, Verb, Adjective, Adverb).

The Algebraic Vocab Formula

Think of words as mathematical equations:

In (Not) + Cred (Believe) + Ible (Able to be) = Incredible (Unbelievable)

Bene (Good) + Fact (To do/make) + Or (One who) = Benefactor (One who does good/gives help)

Miso (Hate) + Gyn (Woman) + Ist (Person) = Misogynist (One who hates women)

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Detailed Explanations & Theory

Part A: High-Frequency Root Words (The Core Pillars)

The following tables contain the most frequently tested Latin and Greek roots in competitive examinations.

Roots Related to People, Marriage, and Gender

Root Word	Origin/Meaning	Key Derivative	Exam Definition
Anthropo	Greek: Human / Mankind	Philanthropy	Love for mankind; charity.
Andro	Greek: Male / Masculine	Androgynous	Having both male and female characteristics.
Gyn	Greek: Female / Woman	Gynecology	Branch of medicine dealing with women's health.
Gamy	Greek: Marriage	Monogamy	The practice of being married to one person at a time.
Demo	Greek: People	Demagogue	A leader who seeks support by appealing to popular desires rather than using rational argument.

Roots Related to Speech, Mind, and Feeling

Root Word	Origin/Meaning	Key Derivative	Exam Definition
Loqu / Locut	Latin: To talk / speak	Loquacious	Extremely talkative; garrulous.
Dict	Latin: To say / speak	Malediction	A curse; words uttered to bring about evil.
Path	Greek: Feeling / Suffering	Apathy	Lack of feeling, emotion, or interest.

Cred	Latin: To believe	Credulous	Too ready to believe things; gullible.
Anim	Latin: Mind, Soul, Spirit	Magnanimous	Generous in forgiving an insult or injury.

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Part B: Thematic One-Word Substitutions

Competitive exams frequently group one-word substitutions into specific conceptual categories. Mastering these themes ensures rapid recollection during the exam.

System of Governance (-cracy / -archy)

- Monarchy: Rule by a single person (king or queen).
- Oligarchy: Rule by a small, privileged group of people.
- Plutocracy: Government governed by the wealthy class.
- Anarchy: A state of lawlessness due to the absence of governmental authority.
- Theocracy: Rule by religious leaders/priests in the name of God.
- Kakistocracy: Government by the least qualified or most unprincipled citizens.

Specialized Killings and Crimes (-cide)

- Patricide: The killing of one's father.
- Matricide: The killing of one's mother.
- Fratricide: The killing of one's brother.
- Sororicide: The killing of one's sister.
- Uxoricide: The killing of one's wife.
- Regicide: The killing of a king.

+P IMPORTANT POINT
+P IMPORTANT:

KEY NOTE

While -cide denotes killing, the root Gen refers to race or kind. Therefore, Genocide is the deliberate killing of a large group of people, especially those of a particular nation, ethnic group, or race.

Worked Examples & Applications

Let us analyze how these concepts are applied to solve complex exam questions.

Contextual Usage & Sentence Completion

Example 1 (Sentence Completion)

KEY NOTE

The politician's speech was filled with empty _____; he spoke for two hours without proposing a single concrete policy.

KEY NOTE

KEY NOTE

Options: (A) Garrulity, (B) Rhetoric, (C) Brevity, (D) Taciturnity

KEY NOTE**KEY NOTE**

Analysis:

KEY NOTE

Look at the clue: "empty... spoke for two hours without proposing a single concrete policy." This indicates high-sounding language with little meaning.

KEY NOTE

Brevity (briefness) and Taciturnity (habitual silence) are antonyms of the clue and can be eliminated.

KEY NOTE

Garrulity means talkativeness, but Rhetoric specifically means the art of effective or persuasive speaking/writing, especially language designed to have an impressive effect on its audience but often regarded as lacking in sincerity or meaningful content.

KEY NOTE**KEY NOTE**

Correct Answer: (B) Rhetoric

Example 2 (Synonym/Antonym Pair Analysis)**KEY NOTE**

Find the Synonym of OBSEQUIIOUS.

KEY NOTE**KEY NOTE**

Options: (A) Domineering, (B) Fawning, (C) Mutinous, (D) Assertive

KEY NOTE**KEY NOTE**

Analysis:

KEY NOTE

Root Breakdown: Ob- (toward) + sequi (to follow). An obsequious person is a "follower," subservient, or excessively eager to please.

KEY NOTE

Domineering and Assertive represent the opposite behaviour (leading/controlling).

KEY NOTE
Mutinous means rebellious (refusing to follow).

KEY NOTE
Fawning means displaying exaggerated flattery or affection; obsequious.

KEY NOTE

KEY NOTE
Correct Answer: (B) Fawning

PYQ Discussion & Exam Trends

Recent Trends in SSC CGL & CHSL (2020–2024)

Analysis of past papers indicates a clear shift from obscure literary words to moderate-level contextual vocabulary and etymological roots.

[SSC Vocabulary Weightage Chart]

- Synonyms/Antonyms: 30% (Contextual & Direct)
- One-word Subs: 30% (Thematic: Gov, Killings, Phobias)
- Spelling Errors: 20% (Confusing double consonants)
- Idioms & Phrases: 20% (Historical & Nautical roots)

EXAM TREND & FOCUS
PREVIOUS YEAR TREND:

KEY NOTE
In recent SSC CGL tiers, words related to human behavior and social interactions (e.g., Gregarious, Misanthrope, Altruistic, Egotistical) have appeared in more than 15 shifts. Memorizing the roots Greg (flock), Anthrop (human), and Alter (other) helps answer these questions in seconds.

Shortcuts & Exam Tricks

Trick 1: The "Tone Identification" Technique (Positive/Negative Charging)

When you do not know the exact meaning of a word, determine whether its tone is Positive (+), Negative (-), or Neutral (N) using its prefixes.

Prefixes like \textit{bene-, eu-, pro-, extra-} \to \textbf{Positive (+)}

Prefixes like \textit{mal-, mis-, dis-, in-, un-, non-, a-, an-, de-} \to \textbf{Negative (-)}

SMART TRICK
SMART TRICK:

KEY NOTE
If the sentence calls for a positive word:

KEY NOTE

The philanthropist made a _____ donation to the hospital.*

KEY NOTE**KEY NOTE**

If the options are: (A) Malevolent (-), (B) Parsimonious (-), (C) Munificent (+), (D) Malicious (-)

KEY NOTE**KEY NOTE**

Even if you do not know the meaning of Munificent, you can eliminate (A), (B), and (D) because of their negative prefixes/ meanings, leaving Munificent (generous) as the only logical option.

Trick 2: Suffix Scanning for Part of Speech Match

A Synonym or Antonym of a word must belong to the same part of speech as the question word.

- If the question word ends in -ous, -ive, -al, -ful (Adjectives), the answer must be an adjective.
- If the question word ends in -tion, -ity, -ness, -ance (Nouns), the answer must be a noun.

Memory Tricks & Mnemonics

To lock highly abstract words into your long-term memory, use phonetic associations or vivid mental images.

- Garrulous (Talkative):
- Mnemonic*: Imagine a girl named Garry who talks continuously like a rail train (Garr-u-lous).
- Abstemious (Moderate in eating/drinking):
- Mnemonic*: Focus on Abst- which sounds like Abstain (to avoid/refrain from). An abstemious person abstains from excess.
- Pugnacious (Eager to fight):
- Mnemonic*: Relate it to a Pug (the dog breed). Imagine a small, angry pug dog trying to pick a fight with a massive bulldog.

Ø=Ü; SMART TRICK

Ø>Ýà MEMORY TRICK:

KEY NOTE

Kakistocracy (Government by the worst people):

KEY NOTE

Think of the word Kaka (slang/poop in several European languages). A kakistocracy is literally a "poopy" government run by the most corrupt, worst citizens!

Common Mistakes to Avoid**Confusing Homophones and Homographs**

Many aspirants lose marks by confusing words that sound similar but have completely different meanings.

- Altruism vs. Altarism:

- Altruism (from Alter* = other) means selflessness.
- Altar* is a raised table in a place of worship.
- Compliment vs. Complement:
- Compliment* (with an i) is an expression of praise.
- Complement (with an e) means something that completes or brings to perfection (e.g., The red wine complements the steak*).

Ø=b" COMMON MISTAKE ALERT

Ø=b" COMMON MISTAKE:

KEY NOTE

Do not assume that the prefix In- always means "not".

KEY NOTE

While Incurable means not curable, Valuable and Invaluable do not have opposite meanings. Invaluable means priceless (extremely valuable, beyond estimation), not "useless".

Summary & Key Takeaways

1. Etymology is your best asset: Always break down an unfamiliar word into its Prefix, Root, and Suffix before attempting to guess.
2. Context is crucial: Pay close attention to the transition words (however, although, and, because) in contextual vocab questions to determine if the blank needs a synonym or an antonym.
3. Charge the Words: Classify options into Positive (+) or Negative (-) categories to quickly eliminate incorrect choices.
4. Thematic Grouping: Group One-Word Substitutions into clear, structured categories (killings, governments, study fields) to optimize retention.

Practice Questions with Solutions

Questions

1. Select the Synonym of the given word:

EPHEMERAL

- (A) Eternal
- (B) Transient
- (C) Monumental
- (D) Substantial

2. Select the Antonym of the given word:

ALACRITY

- (A) Apathy
- (B) Zeal
- (C) Promptness
- (D) Dispatch

3. Choose the correct One-Word Substitution for the following phrase:

A person who hates and avoids other people.

- (A) Misogynist

- (B) Misanthrope
- (C) Misogamist
- (D) Altruist

4. Select the Synonym of the given word:

CACOPHONY

- (A) Euphony
- (B) Harmony
- (C) Harsh discordance of sound
- (D) Melodious cadence

5. Select the Antonym of the given word:

PROCLIVITY

- (A) Antipathy
- (B) Propensity
- (C) Inclination
- (D) Predilection

6. Fill in the blank with the most appropriate word:

The detective's _____ investigation left no stone unturned, leading to the ultimate arrest of the perpetrator.

- (A) Cursory
- (B) Perfunctory
- (C) Meticulous
- (D) Desultory

7. Choose the correct One-Word Substitution for the following phrase:

Government run by the wealthiest class of citizens.

- (A) Oligarchy
- (B) Democracy
- (C) Plutocracy
- (D) Kakistocracy

8. Identify the misspelled word from the options below:

- (A) Accorrence
- (B) Accommodation
- (C) Millennium
- (D) Liaison

9. Select the Synonym of the given word:

GARRULOUS

- (A) Reticent
- (B) Taciturn
- (C) Talkative
- (D) Laconic

10. Select the Antonym of the given word:

ESTRANGED

- (A) Alienated
- (B) Reconciled
- (C) Separated
- (D) Hostile

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Detailed Solutions

1. Correct Answer: (B) Transient

Explanation: Ephemeral comes from the Greek ephemerous, meaning "lasting only for a day" or short-lived. Transient means lasting only for a short time. Eternal is its antonym.
2. Correct Answer: (A) Apathy

Explanation: Alacrity means briskness, cheerful readiness, or eagerness (Positive/Active tone). Its antonym must mean indifference or lack of interest, which is Apathy. Zeal and Promptness are synonyms.
3. Correct Answer: (B) Misanthrope

Explanation: Root analysis: Miso (hate) + Anthropos (human). A Misanthrope is a hater of mankind. Misogynist means woman-hater, and Misogamist means marriage-hater.
4. Correct Answer: (C) Harsh discordance of sound

Explanation: Root analysis: Caco (bad/harsh) + Phon (sound). Thus, Cacophony refers to bad, harsh, or discordant noises. Euphony and Harmony are antonyms (meaning sweet sound).
5. Correct Answer: (A) Antipathy

Explanation: Proclivity means a natural inclination or tendency toward something. Its antonym is Antipathy, which means a strong feeling of dislike or aversion. Propensity and Predilection are synonyms.
6. Correct Answer: (C) Meticulous

Explanation: The sentence says "left no stone unturned," which implies extreme care, precision, and thoroughness. Meticulous means showing great attention to detail; very careful and precise. cursory and Perfunctory mean brief and careless.
7. Correct Answer: (C) Plutocracy

Explanation: Root analysis: Pluto (wealth) + Cracy (rule/power). Government governed by the wealthy is a Plutocracy.
8. Correct Answer: (A) Accorrence

Explanation: The correct spelling is Occurrence (derived from the verb occur, doubling the 'c' and the 'r'). All other words are spelled correctly.
9. Correct Answer: (C) Talkative

Explanation: Garrulous means excessively talkative, especially on trivial matters. Reticent, Taciturn, and Laconic are all synonyms of each other, meaning reserved or saying very little.
10. Correct Answer: (B) Reconciled

Explanation: Estranged means no longer close or affectionate to someone; alienated. Its antonym is Reconciled, which means restored to friendly relations.

-- Final One-Page Quick Revision Sheet

High-Yield Vocabulary Formulas

Root / Prefix	Semantic Meaning	Common Exam Examples
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Ambi- / Amph-	Both / Double	Ambivalent (conflicted), Ambidextrous (using both hands equally).
Bene- / Bon-	Good / Well	Benevolent (kind), Bonafide (genuine/in good faith).
Mal-	Bad / Evil	Malevolent (wishing evil), Malignant (harmful/cancerous).
Loqu- / Locut-	Speak / Talk	Garrulous / Loquacious (talkative), Circumlocution (talking in circles).
Plac-	To please / soothe	Placate (to calm down), Implacable (unable to be appeased).
Greg-	Flock / Herd / Group	Gregarious (sociable), Congregation (gathering of people).
Fid-	Faith / Trust	Fidelity (faithfulness), Diffident (lacking self-trust/shy).
cide	Act of killing	Regicide (killing of king), Uxoricide (killing of wife).
cracy	Type of Rule	Plutocracy (rule by rich), Kakistocracy (rule by the worst).

Top 10 High-Frequency Confusing Words

1.

Acquisitive (greedy/eager to acquire) vs. Inquisitive (curious/inquiring).
2.

Affable (friendly/easy to talk to) vs. Effable (utterable/able to be expressed).
3.

Egoist (self-centered person) vs. Egotist (boastful talker).
4.

Allay (to alleviate/calm) vs. Ally (a partner/supporter) vs. Alley (a narrow passage).
5.

Expatriate (living outside native country) vs. Eradicate (destroy completely).
6.

Imminent (about to happen) vs. Eminent (famous/distinguished) vs. Immanent (inherent/pervading).
7.

Incipient (in an initial stage) vs. Insipid (lacking flavor/boring).
8.

Deprecate (express disapproval of) vs. Depreciate (decrease in value).
9.

Venal (corruptible/susceptible to bribery) vs. Venial (excusable/minor sin).
10.

Avaricious (greedy for wealth) vs. Voracious (extremely hungry/ravenous).

' QUICK REVISION

' FINAL REVISION:

KEY NOTE

Remember: Etymology + Contextual Tone (Positive/Negative) = 100\% Vocab Exam Success

-- Ø=P Funny Memory Mode (Visual & Phonetic Mnemonics)

Use these mental flashcards to associate meanings with fun, memorable scenarios.

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MEMORY CARD 1

WORD : LOQUACIOUS (Adjective)

MEANING: Extremely talkative; long-winded.
Focus on "LOQUA". It sounds like "LOK-SABHA" (Parliament).
"Loqua" -> "Lok Sabha" -> Where politicians talk non-stop without listening!
about his pet iguana.

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MEMORY CARD 2
WORD : PUGNACIOUS (Adjective)
MEANING: Eager or quick to argue, quarrel, or fight.
Look at "PUG-". It refers to a small Pug dog.
"Pugnacious" -> "Pug Nation" -> An imaginary island ruled by angry little
pugs who want to fight everyone!
from our tree fell on his driveway.

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MEMORY CARD 3
WORD : MUNIFICENT (Adjective)
MEANING: Extremely generous; bountiful.
"Muni" in Sanskrit/Hindi means a "sage" or "saint."
"Muni-Sufficient" -> A saint (Muni) who has sufficient wisdom and shares
it generously with everyone!
The billionaire's munificent donation funded the construction of three new
cancer research centers.

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MEMORY CARD 4
WORD : MEGALOMANIA (Noun)

MEANING: Obsession with the exercise of power, especially in the domination
of others.
"Mega" means massive, and "Mania" means madness.
"Mega" + "Mania" -> A person with a giant ego who believes they are born to
rule the solar system!
The dictator's megalomania was evident in his plan to build a 200-foot-tall
gold statue of himself in the city square.

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